

“AINOLA,” SIBELIUS’S HOUSE

Sibelius is shown here with members of his family in the grounds of his house, “Ainola,” at the picturesque lakeside village of Järvenpää.

The war years

Next came a symphonic poem, *The Oceanides*, evoking the sea-nymphs of Greek mythology. The piece was commissioned by Carl Stoeckel, a wealthy US businessman who ran a music festival in Norfolk, Connecticut. Sibelius arrived home from an acclaimed US visit just before World War I broke out in 1914 and thereafter found himself unable to travel abroad, with royalties cut off from his German publishers, where many of his works had been placed.

Nonetheless, the composer made good progress on a Fifth Symphony for his fiftieth birthday concert in 1915. He then withdrew it for revision, conducting a new version a year later; for this, he spliced the two opening movements together, so that the first flowed into the second. Still not happy, he worked on a final revision while the Civil War (see box) raged around him, and his longed-for independent Finnish Republic came into being.

Two more symphonies followed in 1923 and 1924: the Sixth Symphony’s quiet, poised tone and four-movement design are very different from the grandly glowing single movement of his Seventh (which was originally named *Fantasia sinfonica*). Then a commission arrived from the New York Philharmonic Orchestra. The result was *Tapiola*, named after the forest god of Finnish